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Wherefore Does the Earth Quake? Artistic Exchange and the Construction of Buddhist Homelands in Andhra and Sri Lanka

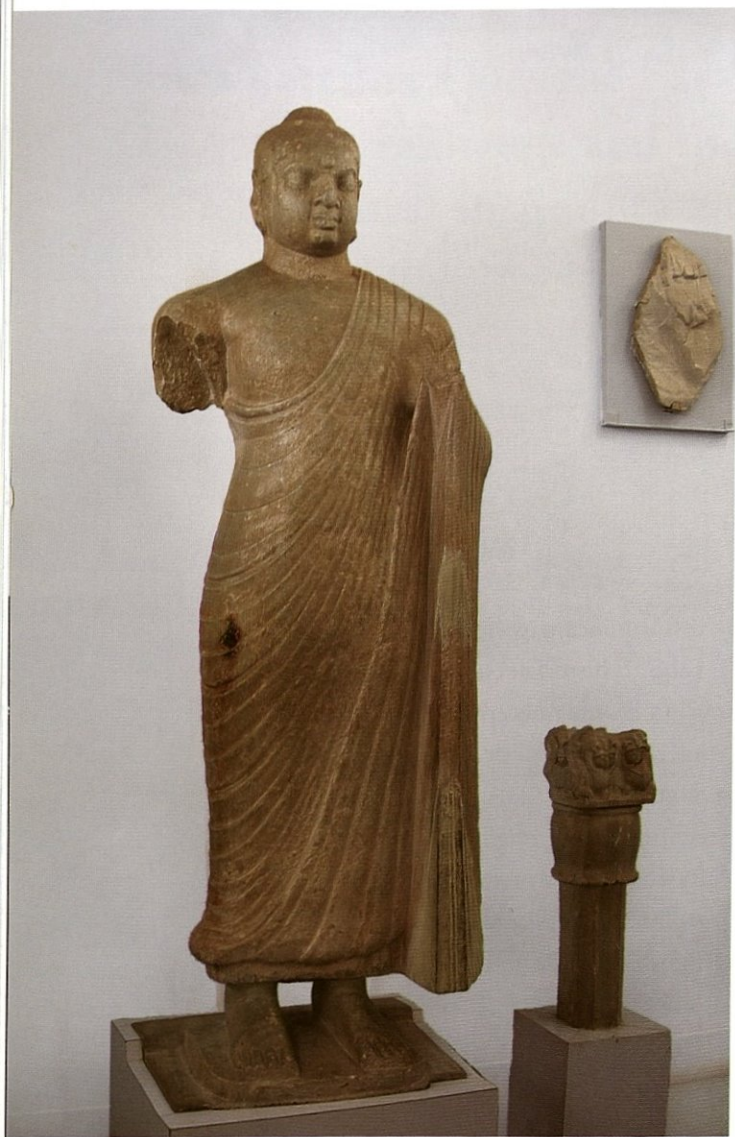
Catherine Becker



Although rich with sculptural remains from its magnificent towering stupas, the city of Anuradhapura poses a number of challenges for the art historian curious about how some of its inhabitants in the early centuries of the Common Era not only envisioned the construction and adornment of Buddhist monuments, but also understood the place of Anuradhapura in an interconnected Buddhist world. How did Buddhist communities in Anuradhapura understand the relationships between stupas and the Buddha's teachings? How might the material culture of Buddhist communities in Anuradhapura reveal the city to be constructed as a distinct Buddhist homeland and as a participant in a broader Buddhist imaginary, specifically with ties to communities in India, including sites associated with the life of the Buddha and the active Buddhist communities that flourished along the Krishna river valley in Andhra?¹ The colonial and nationalist politics surrounding the early 20th-century construction of the "sacred city" of Anuradhapura have obscured these questions.² Moreover, with Ananda Coomaraswamy's 1908 pronouncement that "Sinhalese art is essentially Indian", nationalist rhetoric has also inflected scholarly discussions of the artistic connections between Sri Lanka and India, with some of the most intense arguments swirling around anthropomorphic representations of the Buddha.³

A cursory consideration of Buddha images from Anuradhapura and Andhra reveals key similarities in the sculpture of these two regions and illuminates some of the tensions that underpin the scholarly discussions of the artistic ties between India and Sri Lanka. As a representative comparison, the mighty colossal standing Buddha from Aukana, located southwest of Anuradhapura (figure 1), shares a columnar form and a distinctive over-the-shoulder sweep of the robes with the more human-sized standing image of the Buddha from Amaravati in Andhra Pradesh (figure 2). Yet, separated by hundreds of miles and several centuries, these images also reveal significant differences, most notably in scale but also in the treatment of the body beneath the robes, with Diran Dohanian noting that the "full and fleshy" quality of the Aukana Buddha's soft hips and delicately protruding stomach is absent in earlier "Amaravati style" Buddha images.⁴ Dohanian suggests that this shift toward softer forms reflects the emergence of Gupta-style imagery in Andhra, which, in turn, is imported to Sri Lanka in the 7th and 8th centuries. Thus, for Dohanian, the Aukana Buddha reflects several centuries of artistic links between Andhra and Sri Lanka. In contrast, D.T. Devendra notes the clear connections between Buddha images from Andhra and those from Sri Lanka, but remarks that whether such stylistic and

1
Standing Buddha, Aukana,
6th–8th century.
Photograph: Sebastian
Posingis/ThreeBlindMen.



iconographic similarities “originated in Ceylon or India, is a point which needs investigation”.⁵ Devendra also takes pleasure in noting when a Buddhist sculpture from Sri Lanka “is a distinctly superior work” to similar imagery found in Andhra Pradesh. Specifically, he argues for the superiority of a standing Buddha image from Maha Illuppallama when compared to similar sculptures from Nagarjunakonda, but without providing photographs of either image to assist the reader in assessing his partisan claim.

In his expansive study of the extant remains of Sri Lanka’s early Buddhist sculpture, Ulrich von Schroeder assembles a photographic archive that presents sculptures from Sri Lanka

alongside comparative examples from Andhra. John Holt and Sree Padma state that von Schroeder’s evidence makes “abundantly clear that Buddhist Sri Lanka’s material religious culture of the 1st millennium CE owes much of its inspiration to Andhra creations”.⁶ Yet, this statement fails to address why certain art from Andhra might have been inspiring and ignores some striking dissimilarities between the sculpture from Buddhist sites along the Krishna river valley and in Anuradhapura, notably the wealth of relief sculptures featuring scenes of devotion and narratives in Andhra and the absence of such imagery in Anuradhapura. The absence of sculptural narratives from Sri Lanka is all the more striking, as Sri Lanka boasts a robust literary tradition in the form of the Pali chronicles, the earliest of which, the *Dipavamsa* and *Mahavamsa*, are often consulted as historical accounts of the founding of Sri Lanka. However, these texts also function as polemical narratives detailing the royal patronage of the Maha Vihara in Anuradhapura and as sources of potential mental transformation in their listeners.⁷ In contrast, no such textual tradition can be associated with the Buddhist communities in Andhra, and, indeed, scholars have struggled to understand the range of texts that circulated within Andhra’s Buddhist communities.⁸

Eschewing the scholarly debates around issues of artistic influence, this article refocuses the lens through which we view the relationship between Buddhist communities in Andhra’s Krishna river valley and Anuradhapura. I briefly examine some of the motifs shared between these regions, not to determine which region influenced the other, but to introduce evidence of shared concerns about how to construct sacred space. This article also considers shared narrative strategies between these two regions. As something of an experiment, I juxtapose these two regional story-telling traditions—that is to say, narrative sculpture from Andhra and

2
Standing Buddha, Amaravati,
2nd century, now at the
Archaeological Museum,
Amaravati. Photograph:
Catherine Becker. Reproduced
with the permission of the
Archaeological Survey of India.

3

Depiction of a moonstone on a drum slab, Amaravati, 2nd century, now at the Archaeological Museum, Amaravati. Photograph: Catherine Becker. Reproduced with the permission of the Archaeological Survey of India.



key passages from Sri Lanka's *Mahavamsa*—in order to suggest that the rhetorical strategies employed in both sources advance claims for unique and legitimate Buddhist homelands in regions that are temporally and geographically remote from the life of the historical Buddha. This cross-media comparison reveals future directions for the study of artistic and cultural interaction among the Buddhist communities in Andhra and Sri Lanka during the early centuries of the Common Era.

A comparison of select relief sculptures from Buddhist sites in Andhra and Anuradhapura reveals an affinity in the motifs chosen for the adornment of sacred spaces, including image

shrines and stupas. The moonstone, which marked the thresholds to stupas and other shrines in both regions, is perhaps the most widely recognized commonality. In Andhra, moonstones adorn thresholds that appear in the gateways of stupas depicted within relief sculptures, as demonstrated by a lotus-flower moonstone in a detail of a scene of stupa veneration (figure 3). Relatively simple moonstones have also been recovered from sites at Nagarjunakonda (figure 4). While some of Andhra's moonstones are quite plain, others appear carved with bands of foliage or running animals along the outer edge. As if elaborating on a theme, some of the moonstones found at



4

Moonstone from Nagarjunakonda, 3rd century, now at the Archaeological Museum, Nagarjunakonda. Photograph: Catherine Becker. Reproduced with the permission of the Archaeological Survey of India.

5

Moonstone at Abhayagiri monastic complex, Anuradhapura, 6th–8th century. Courtesy Department of Archaeology, Sri Lanka.



several of Anuradhapura's Buddhist sites (and later at Polonnaruva) are much more ornately carved, as exemplified by the moonstone that marked the threshold to a shrine in a monastic complex at Abhayagiri (figure 5).⁹ Bands of wave-like flames, creeping foliage, and prancing animals create a lively surface that functions as an animated and auspicious introduction to a sacred space.

Other intriguing parallels in the relief sculptures from these two regions include the appearance of similar subject matter. For example, the figure of the cakravartin or universal monarch, which adorned a number of stupas in Andhra, also makes an appearance at Anuradhapura.¹⁰ A detail of a frieze from Nagarjunakonda features the world ruler raising one hand as if poised to strike his other

hand, which is clenched in a fist—a gesture that evokes the cakravartin's magical ability to cause a downpour of golden coins (figure 6). Similarly, a relief sculpture, that as of 2013 adorned the reconstructed Jetavana stupa in Anuradhapura, depicts a cakravartin making the same bold gesture with one hand raised as if preparing to strike the other hand (figure 7). The Jetavana stupa also includes several impressive depictions of theriomorphic polycephalous nagas, including an alert cobra with its scaly body undulating in a rhythmic pattern and an umbrella sheltering its seven heads, each with its hood expanded as if prepared to strike (figure 8). Similar relief sculptures have been found at several sites in Andhra, including a plump serpent with five hoods from the stupa at Dhulikatta (figure 9).¹¹

6
Frieze with cakravartin,
Nagarjunakonda, 3rd century,
now at the Archaeological
Museum, Nagarjunakonda.
Photograph: Catherine
Becker. Reproduced with
the permission of the
Archaeological Survey of India.





7
Relief sculpture with cakravartin, Jetavana stupa, Anuradhapura, 3rd century. Photograph: Department of Archaeology, Sri Lanka.

8
Relief sculpture with polycephalous naga, Jetavana stupa, Anuradhapura, 3rd century. Courtesy Department of Archaeology, Sri Lanka.

In addition to these select examples of shared motifs in Andhra and Anuradhapura, relief sculptures carved of the distinctive fine-grained limestone associated with Buddhist sites in Andhra Pradesh were imported to Sri Lanka.¹² Several of these limestone pieces are presently in museum collections in Sri Lanka,¹³ including two finials with female figures that were excavated in 1982 near the base of the Jetavana stupa (figures 10 and 11). Seemingly deposited in the 3rd century of the Common Era during the construction of the stupa, the so-called “Jetavana treasure” included these limestone fragments from Andhra along with ceramic vessels, carnelian and glass intaglios, and ivory and gold objects.¹⁴ The diversity of objects found during these excavations suggests that Anuradhapura enjoyed active trade connections across South and West Asia. The rendering of the limestone female figures from

the Jetavana treasure—especially their elongated limbs, slender waists and round hips—recalls sculptures of female figures recovered from sites in Andhra, such as a now-damaged portion of a frieze found at Nagarjunakonda (figure 12). Moreover, this representation of the female body appears to be echoed in the relief sculptures carved in stone local to Anuradhapura for the Jetavana stupa, including a relief of a lithe and graceful female devotee raising a bouquet of flowers (figure 13). When viewed alongside the figures from Andhra, this female devotee demonstrates that an aesthetic preference for slender figures informed sculptural production at stupas in both Andhra and Anuradhapura.

Despite these examples of shared preferences for adorning sacred spaces, key differences also mark the art of these regions, such as the absence from the sculpture of Anuradhapura of elaborate narratives related to the final life

9

Relief sculpture with polycephalous naga, Dhulikatta stupa, 2nd–1st century BCE, now at the Amaravati Museum and Interpretation Centre. Photograph: Catherine Becker. Reproduced with the permission of the Government of Andhra Pradesh Department of Archaeology and Museums.



of the Buddha and selected episodes from his past lives.¹⁵ In contrast, the narrative sculptures from Andhra are so numerous that many scenes have thwarted easy identification and continue to puzzle scholars.¹⁶ My consideration of connections between Andhra and Sri Lanka has been inspired, in part, by one such damaged sculptural fragment that once adorned the railing of the main stupa at Amaravati and is now housed in the British Museum (figure 14). Akira Shimada has convincingly dated this limestone coping fragment to the second half of the 1st century CE,¹⁷ but the narrative that enlivens this stone has yet to be satisfactorily identified.

At first glance, the scene depicted on the railing fragment suggests the unfolding of a continuous narrative, one that includes a lively procession, a stupa, an assembly and an architectural setting. Phillipe Stern and

Mireille Bénisti refer to it simply as a scene of stupa veneration.¹⁸ Douglas Barrett hazards an interpretation that this scene represents the Buddha's visit to Kapilavastu and King Siddhodana's encounter with his newly enlightened son. Yet, Barrett seems not entirely convinced by his own interpretation and remarks that "if this interpretation is correct, it is noteworthy that the Buddha is thrice represented without a halo".¹⁹ These Buddha-like figures also lack other obvious marks of Buddhahood—missing is the ushnisha (cranial protuberance), the urna (the flaming tuft of hair between the Buddha's eyes), the elongated earlobes and the snail-shell curls—all of which are visible in a slightly later depiction of the Buddha from Nagarjunakonda (figure 15). This relief from Nagarjunakonda, which is a detail of the story of the conversion of Nanda, also reveals a clear contrast between representations



of the Buddha and his monastic followers, who lack halos and have smooth pates. The railing fragment in the British Museum most likely depicts a narrative involving members of the monastic community but not the Buddha himself.

If we set aside Barrett's assumption that the scene depicts an episode from the life of the Buddha, the Amaravati coping fragment becomes a tale of royal and monastic interaction and the subsequent founding of a monastery. Moving from left to right across the relief, the viewer encounters a procession of mounted soldiers and musicians on foot. In the upper register, two royal or wealthy figures on an

elephant come thundering out of a city gate. In the foreground, the musicians seem to step over a rocky formation, which, in the visual shorthand of Andhra's sculptors, usually indicates mountainous terrain, before reaching a stupa. To the right of the stupa, a figure in monastic robes levitates while wealthy devotees and monastic onlookers press their hands together in respect. The same crowd of lay and monastic followers seems to be depicted again further to the right, seated and listening to a preaching monk, with a large tree in the background. The fragment ends with a scene in front of a complex of buildings. A richly dressed lay donor pours water over the hands

10 and 11
 Finials with female figures imported to Sri Lanka from Andhra Pradesh and incorporated in the Jetavana stupa, Anuradhapura, 3rd century. Courtesy Department of Archaeology, Sri Lanka.



12
Part of a frieze with a female figure, Nagarjunakonda, 3rd century, now at the Archaeological Museum, Nagarjunakonda. Photograph: Catherine Becker. Reproduced with the permission of the Archaeological Survey of India.



13
Relief sculpture with a female figure, Jetavana stupa, Anuradhapura, 3rd century. Courtesy Department of Archaeology, Sri Lanka.

of a monk, presumably to ratify the gift of the monastic compound in the background.

Some of the events depicted on this relief correspond to descriptions of the monk Mahinda's transmission of Buddhism to Sri Lanka during the reign of Ashoka. This story, known from texts such as the *Dipavamsa* and *Mahavamsa*, and the much-later *Thupavamsa*,²⁰ describes Mahinda as rising up in the air with an entourage of monks in order to journey from India to the Missaka-mountain near Anuradhapura.²¹ According to the *Mahavamsa* version of these events, at the moment of Mahinda's arrival King Devanampiya Tissa had just exited the palace with his own entourage

of hunters and begun the journey to Missaka-mountain, perhaps paralleled in the relief from Amaravati by the small rocky mound in the foreground. Although initially afraid when they first encountered Mahinda and his fellow monks, the king and his hunting party soon laid down their weapons and Mahinda preached to the king. Then the *Mahavamsa* details some anxiety on the part of the king about properly hosting the monks, particularly regarding where the monks might reside. After other options are rejected, Mahamegha-park was identified as a suitable location. The text describes how the king "poured water (in token) of giving, over the hand of the thera Mahinda with the words: "This

Mahamegha-park do I give to the brotherhood.' As the water fell on the ground, the great earth quaked. And the protector of the earth asked the (thera): 'Wherefore does the earth quake?' And he replied: 'Because the doctrine is (from henceforth) founded in the island.'²² Thus, the first monastery in Sri Lanka was inaugurated.

While sculptors in Andhra and, indeed everywhere, were necessarily selective in their choice of the key episodes from the larger narratives they depicted, the text of the *Mahavamsa* contains a great deal of information that is not visible on this coping fragment. Rather than insist on the influence of one storytelling tradition upon the other, I propose that we see a functional similarity, in that both of these documents attempt to record the founding of a monastery or the bringing of the dharma to a new region, specifically at the hands of miracle-performing monks with the ability to charm gifts of land from willing royal patrons. Just as the *Mahavamsa* positions Devanampiya Tissa as an ideal Buddhist ruler, so too this relief sculpture seems to depict the cultivation of a generous elite patron.

Delving further into the *Mahavamsa's* account of Mahinda's interactions with King Devanampiya Tissa reveals not only the monk to be something of a savvy property developer but also some additional parallels between the narrative and the fragment in the British Museum. After the founding of the vihara at the Mahamegha-park, the king and Mahinda surveyed the surrounding landscape, with Mahinda prophesizing the locations of various structures in the monastic complex. Eventually, the king and Mahinda came to a spot within the royal park where the text tells us "the Great thupa (afterwards) stood". After the dharmic duo offered flowers, the earth quaked and Mahinda proclaimed, "This place, O great king, which has been visited by four Buddhas is worthy of a thupa, to be a blessing and happiness

to beings."²³ This is not so much a prophecy, as a revelation, in which Mahinda demonstrated to the king that the island had long been a sacred space, visited by four Buddhas of the past. Mahinda brought the dharma to the island of Sri Lanka, but, of course, it was always already there. Mahinda also revealed that, with the assistance of the king, a physical manifestation of the dharma—a stupa—would soon be restored.

The *Mahavamsa's* discussion of visits by four past Buddhas also helps to elucidate the four trees that punctuate the periphery of the stupa in the Amaravati fragment. Perhaps these trees visually refer to the visitation at this site of four past Buddhas. The trunk of the tree in the left foreground includes a base, reminding the viewer that this tree is maintained through human intervention. Careful examination reveals a pair of tiny footprints just visible on this base. These footprints suggest both the past presence of a Buddha and also a site that continues to be worthy of veneration. While textual storytelling traditions can employ vivid descriptions to convey concepts like temporal progression or flashbacks, visual storytelling must rely on other tools. Indeed, visual imagery has some unique advantages in this context. For example, the visual representation of a site can convey the simultaneity of past and present in a manner that is not entirely possible in oral or textual narratives. Here the stupa with its four trees and footprints visually marks a sacred space that collapses past and present, as the past presence of four Buddhas might mark this site's long sacred history and inspire present and future acts of devotion, such as the building of a new stupa.

The *Mahavamsa* further explores how the past presence of Buddhas on the island authorizes the construction of stupas where the Buddha Shakyamuni's relics will be available for veneration. Not long after Mahinda and

14
Railing coping fragment,
Amaravati, 1st–2nd century,
now at the British Museum,
London. © The Trustees of the
British Museum.

his monks were comfortably ensconced in the Mahamegha-park, it became apparent that they required a retreat for the rainy season, which the king dutifully provided. Then, after the rainy season, Mahinda complained to the king, "There is nothing here for us to worship."²⁴ And, so, Mahinda set in motion the construction of a stupa on Missaka-mountain with willing and lavish patronage from the king. The monk Sumana was deputized to fly to Pataliputra to collect from Ashoka the right collarbone relic to be placed within the stupa. Eventually, a branch of the Bodhi tree from Bodhgaya was also brought to the island by Mahinda's sister, Sanghamitta, and planted within the Mahamegha-park, where a range of miracles marked the auspicious arrival of both the relics and the Bodhi tree cutting (see page 1). Similarly, the Amaravati coping fragment gives prominence both to the stupa and to the large tree surrounded by a platform, perhaps part of a systematic creation of a monastic compound. The miraculous events described within the text are not depicted on what remains of this frieze, and I am not suggesting that this stone fragment is an illustration of the *Mahavamsa*.

Rather, both the relief and the text frame the founding of a new Buddhist community in similar ways. For example, the events are witnessed by groups of at least five monks, which Kevin Trainor, in his analysis of both the *Dipavamsa* and the *Mahavamsa*, has noted is the minimum number of monks required for the founding a new community.²⁵ Moreover, in both the relief sculpture and the text, at least one of these monks has the miraculous ability to levitate. Both sources also feature a king who is conscripted as a patron of a monastery and emphasize markers of sacred space in the form of a stupa and enshrined trees.

The specific appearance of the stupa in the Amaravati relief requires additional consideration. Complete with an ayaka platform (surmounted by five pillars and projecting from the drum of the stupa), a railing with lions guarding the gateway, and a semicircular moonstone in front of the gateway, this stupa greatly resembles what I have elsewhere argued is a characteristic representation of a stupa in Andhra.²⁶ The five pillars, in particular, are a regional feature that appears at sites throughout Andhra. Similarly, the tiny five-headed naga



that inhabits the gateway of this stupa resembles the large-scale depictions of nagas that adorned the drums of freestanding stupas, such as the theriomorphic naga from the stupa at Dhulikatta (figure 9). The naga also seems to have been a potent figure in the Buddhist visual imaginary in Anuradhapura, as suggested by the impressive polycephalous serpents adorning the Jetavana stupa (figure 8). The presence of nagas on stupas suggests that these creatures function as both guardians and devotees. The *Mahavamsa* relates how nagas recovered a cache of relics from the Ramagama stupa in Kapilavastu, which they venerated in their own stupa.²⁷ As the nagas fiercely guarded their portions of the Buddha's relics, Ashoka left this relic deposit undisturbed when undertaking his miraculous relic redistribution campaign. This is also the

very portion of relics that, according to the *Mahavamsa*, was predestined to be enshrined within the massive stupa built by the repentant King Duttagamani for the Maha Vihara in Anuradhapura.²⁸

If we understand the inclusion of the naga in the gateway of the stupa in the Amaravati relief to serve as a sort of label for the presence of a specific cache of the Buddha's relics, the choice to depict a recognizably Andhra-type stupa in the midst of a narrative of royal patronage raises some intriguing questions. Does this depiction of a naga-adorned, Andhra-style stupa reveal a narrative of a pious king from Andhra creating a stupa to house the Ramagama relics?²⁹ Are some of the similarities between this relief and the *Mahavamsa* evidence that this literary tradition informed sculpture in Andhra, or do



the events chronicled in the Pali sources have an Indian origin? These questions are beside the point. Rather, by noting parallels between this relief and tales of the legendary transmission of Buddhism to Sri Lanka, I propose that text and image might have similar functions. If texts like the *Mahavamsa* employ multiple strategies for legitimizing and localizing Buddhism in Anuradhapura, this coping fragment from Amaravati seems to depict a similar tale of legitimization and localization—not with respect to Sri Lanka but to Andhra.

As outlined at the beginning of this article, artistic connections between Buddhist communities in Andhra and Anuradhapura have been recognized in the form of stylistic parallels, the common use of specific motifs, and examples of sculpture imported to Sri Lanka from Andhra. Moreover, inscriptional evidence reveals that monks from Sri Lanka resided at Nagarjunakonda during the 3rd and 4th centuries of the Common Era. Gregory Schopen notes the similarity in language employed in inscriptions at Nagarjunakonda and in the *Dipavamsa*, specifically the appearance of the word “dhatuvara” in both, which Schopen uses to argue that both regions shared a similar conception that “relics are characterized by—full of—exactly the same spiritual forces and faculties that characterize, and, in fact, constitute and animate the living Buddha”.³⁰ While Andhra lacks the sort of textual sources associated with the establishment of Buddhism in Sri Lanka, perhaps, as Schopen’s work has indicated, there are more parallels to be uncovered between these two regions, especially with respect to the use of stories to shape and localize Buddhist communities. If done with care, it might be productive to place text and image alongside each other to trace a more nuanced understanding of the artistic and intellectual exchanges between the Buddhist communities in Andhra and Sri Lanka.

Notes

This article is a revised version of an earlier book chapter: “Mahinda’s Visit to Amaravati? Narrative Connections between Buddhist Communities in Andhra and Sri Lanka”, in *Amaravati: The Art of an Early Buddhist Monument in Context*, edited by Akira Shimada and Michael Willis, London: British Museum Press, 2017, pp. 70–78.

- 1 I use “Andhra” throughout this article, as the main Buddhist sites in question—Amaravati and Nagarjunakonda—are within the borders of Andhra Pradesh. However, with the creation of the state of Telangana in 2014, the Krishna river now flows through both states (as well as Karnataka and Maharashtra), and a number of important Buddhist sites are also located within Telangana.
- 2 For discussion of these interventions in the landscape of Anuradhapura, see Pradeep Jeganathan, “Authorizing History, Ordering Land: The Conquest of Anuradhapura”, in *Unmaking the Nation: The Politics of Identity and History in Modern Sri Lanka*, edited by Pradeep Jeganathan and Qadri Ismail, Colombo: Social Scientists’ Association, 1995, pp. 106–36; and Elizabeth Nissan, “History in the Making: Anuradhapura and the Sinhala Buddhist Nation”, in *Identity Consciousness and the Past*, edited by H.L. Seneviratne, Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1997, pp. 23–41. In the early years of the 20th century, systematic excavations at Anuradhapura have begun to shed additional light on the early history of this city. See Robin Coningham, *Anuradhapura*, 3 Vols., Oxford: Society for South Asian Studies and Archaeopress, 1991–2013.
- 3 Ananda Coomaraswamy, *Mediaeval Sinhalese Art*, 1908, New York: Pantheon Books, 1956, p. v. For an overview of the scholarly debates over the depiction of anthropomorphic images of the Buddha, see Ulrich von Schroeder, *Buddhist Sculptures of Sri Lanka*, Hong Kong: Visual Dharma Publications, 1990, pp. 19–41.
- 4 Diran Dohanian, “The Colossal Buddha at Aukana”, *Archives of the Chinese Art Society of*

15

Frieze with a gathering of monks, Nagarjunakonda, 3rd century, now at the Archaeological Museum, Nagarjunakonda. Photograph: Catherine Becker. Reproduced with the permission of the Archaeological Survey of India.

- America*, Vol. 19, 1965, p. 20.
- 5 D.T. Devendra, *Classical Sinhalese Sculpture: 300 BC–AD 1000*, London: Alec Tiranti, 1958, p. 23.
 - 6 John Holt and Sree Padma, “Buddhism in Andhra and Its Influence on Buddhism in Sri Lanka”, in *Buddhism in the Krishna River Valley of Andhra*, edited by Sree Padma and A.W. Barber, Albany: State University of New York Press, 2008, p. 119.
 - 7 For the religious function of these texts, see Kristin Scheible, “‘For the anxious thrill and serene satisfaction of good people’: Rethinking the Pali *Mahavamsa*”, PhD dissertation, Harvard University, 2006.
 - 8 Monika Zin has attempted to trace some of the texts that circulated in Andhra during the 2nd and 3rd centuries of the Common Era. See “The Mukapāṅgu Story in the Madras Government Museum and the Problem of the Textual Affiliations of the Narrative Reliefs in Amaravati and Nagarjunakonda”, *Annali d’Istituto Universitario di Napoli*, Vol. 64, 2004, pp. 157–80.
 - 9 Senarat Paranavitana argues that this moonstone—which adorned the shrine popularly known as “Mahasena’s Pavilion” and can be dated to the 6th–8th centuries, along with several other similarly sculpted moonstones from the Abhayagiri complex—was attached to a shrine that originally housed images of the Buddha. See Senarat Paranavitana, “The Significance of Sinhalese ‘Moonstones’”, *Artibus Asiae*, Vol. 17, 1954, pp. 197–231.
 - 10 For additional depictions of the cakravartin at Buddhist sites in India, see Monika Zin, “Mandhatar, the Universal Monarch, and the Meaning of Representations of the Cakravartin in the Amaravati School and of the Kings on the Kanaganahalli Stupa”, in *Buddhist Narrative in Asia and Beyond: In Honour of HRH Princess Maha Chakri Siringhorn on her Fifty-fifth Birth Anniversary*, edited by Peter Skilling and Justin McDaniel, Vol. 1, Bangkok: Institute of Thai Studies, Chulalongkorn, 2012, pp. 149–64.
 - 11 Located near Karimnagar and along a tributary of the Godavari river, Dhulikatta is in Telangana. Although abundant in the Krishna river valley and Anuradhapura, such depictions of nagas are not unique to these two regions. A spectacular relief of an 11-headed theriomorphic serpent was discovered among the remains of the stupa at Kanaganahalli in Karnataka. See Christian Luczanits’ photograph: <http://www.luczanits.net/gallery3/index.php/docu/Kanganhalli/38-South-west-and-west-sides/Kaganhalli-CL00-38-33>, accessed December 20, 2014. For a discussion of some of the relief sculptures at this site, see Monika Zin, “Narrative Reliefs at Kanaganahalli: A Short Outline of their Importance for Buddhist Studies”, *Marg*, Vol. 63, No. 1, 2011, pp. 12–21.
 - 12 The sculptures from Buddhist sites near the Krishna river are generally carved from a “recrystallized limestone, probably from the Kurnool formation which occurs to the south and north of the river”. See Richard Newman, *The Stone Sculpture of India*, Cambridge, MA: Center for Conservation and Technical Studies, Harvard University Art Museums, 1984, p. 21. In contrast, the stone often used at Anuradhapura’s sites appears to be coarse-grained and is often referred to as dolomite.
 - 13 Ulrich von Schroeder includes some of these Andhra imports in *Buddhist Sculptures of Sri Lanka*. Osmund Bopearachchi is presently working on a more comprehensive catalogue of previously unpublished fragments of white limestone sculpture found throughout Sri Lanka. I am grateful to him for sharing this work-in-progress and his personal photographs with me.
 - 14 Hema Ratnayake, “The Jetavana Treasure”, in *Sri Lanka and the Silk Road of the Sea*, edited by Senake Bandaranayake et al., Colombo: The Sri Lanka National Commission for UNESCO and the Central Cultural Fund, 1990, pp. 44–59.
 - 15 Osmund Bopearachchi has begun to analyse some of the few early sculptural narratives in Sri Lanka. Carved of white limestone, these narrative panels seem to be either imported from Andhra or carved on the island by artists trained in Andhra. See, for example, the relief from the Rankirimada Rajamaha Vihara, Doluwa, Kumbukwewa published in *Contradictions in Textual Narrations and Confusions in Visual Art: Revisiting the Seven Weeks after the Enlightenment of the Buddha*, New Delhi: Manohar, 2016.
 - 16 Not every Buddhist site in Andhra was as richly adorned as the stupas associated with the communities at Amaravati, Nagarjunakonda and other sites near the Krishna river valley. For example, coastal sites such as Bavikonda and Thotlakonda were minimally adorned with relief sculptures.
 - 17 Akira Shimada, *Early Buddhist Architecture in Context: The Great Stupa at Amaravati (ca. 300 BCE–300 CE)*, Leiden and Boston: Brill, 2013, p. 99.
 - 18 Phillipe Stern and Mireille Bénisti, “Evolution du stupa figuré dans les sculpture d’Amaravati”, *Bulletin de la Société des études Indochinoises*, Vol. 27, 1957, pp. 375–80.
 - 19 Douglas Barrett, *Sculptures from Amaravati in the British Museum*, London: The British

- Museum, 1954, p. 67.
- 20 Although they purport to document events from before the Common Era, the scholarly consensus seems to date the *Dipavamsa* and *Mahavamsa* to the 4th or 5th centuries of the Common Era. Holt and Sree Padma, "Buddhism in Andhra", p. 120.
- 21 Wilhelm Geiger, trans., *The Mahavamsa or the Great Chronicle of Ceylon*, Colombo: Ceylon Government Information Department, 1960, pp. 89–90; Bimala Churn Law, trans., *The Legend of the Topes (Thupavamsa)*, Calcutta: The Asiatic Society, 1945, p. 46.
- 22 Geiger, *Mahavamsa*, pp. 93 and 99.
- 23 Ibid., p. 101.
- 24 Ibid., p. 116.
- 25 Kevin Trainor, *Relics, Ritual, and Representation in Buddhism: Rematerializing the Sri Lankan Theravada Tradition*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997, pp. 84–85.
- 26 I also suggest that these idealized depictions of regional stupas shift somewhat over time. See Catherine Becker, *Shifting Stones, Shaping the Past: Sculpture from the Buddhist Stupas of Andhra Pradesh*, New York: Oxford University Press, 2015, pp. 40–43 and 80–81.
- 27 Geiger, *Mahavamsa*, pp. 210–11.
- 28 John Strong, *Relics of the Buddha*, Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2004, Chapter 6.
- 29 Monika Zin has also examined the links between the Ramagama story in the *Mahavamsa* and relief sculptures in South India. See "The Buddha's Relics and the Nagas, an attempt to throw light on some depictions in the Amaravati School", in *Proceedings of the 21st Meeting of the European Association of South Asian Archaeology*, edited by V. Lefevre, Paris, July 2012 (forthcoming).
- 30 Gregory Schopen, "On the Buddha and His Bones", in *Bones, Stones, and Buddhist Monks: Collected Papers on the Archaeology, Epigraphy, and Texts of Monastic Buddhism in India*, Honolulu: University of Hawai'i Press, 1997, p. 154.

Following pages

Sigiriya, or Lion Rock.
Photograph: Siril Bandara.